

Continuation of Post-Pandemic Online Learning Preferences among Children in Sri Lanka: A Qualitative Study

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Background of the Study

COVID-19 and Educational Transformation

- COVID-19 created an unprecedented disruption in global education systems.
- Schools shifted rapidly from traditional classroom learning to online platforms.
- Online learning was initially introduced as a temporary solution for educational continuity.
- However, even after returning to normal schooling, some children continued to prefer online learning.

Sri Lankan Context

- Sri Lanka traditionally follows a teacher-centered, classroom-based education system.
- Yet, the pandemic accelerated children's exposure to:

✓ Digital platforms
✓ Online resources
✓ Independent learning approaches

Research Problem

Although online learning was introduced as a **temporary solution** during the COVID-19 pandemic, a significant number of children continue to prefer online learning over traditional classroom methods even after several years from COVID-19 pandemic. This raises important concerns regarding the effectiveness, social impact and long-term implications of this preference.

However, there is limited context-specific research examining the reasons behind this continued preference, particularly in rural areas such as the Elpitiya Divisional Secretariat Division in the Galle District. Therefore, this study aims to explore the factors influencing children's preference for online learning in the post-pandemic context.

Research Gap

Many studies have been conducted on this topic by the scholars in both broader and more context specific settings covering topics, social barriers to online education, inequality when accessing digital education, rural digital learning gaps, educational performance and effectiveness in a virtual environment. This study is important as it was focused on identifying reasons **why children still prefer and prioritize online learning rather than returning onsite learning** which creates a gap in scholarly work specified to Sri Lanka.

Also, there is limited context-specific research examining the reasons behind this continued preference, particularly in rural areas such as the Elpitiya Divisional Secretariat Division in the Galle District. Therefore, this study aims to explore the factors influencing children's preference for online learning in the post-pandemic context.

Research Objective

To explore the factors that influence continued use of online learning methods among children during post COVID-19.

Research Questions

1. What are children's perceptions regarding online learning during COVID-19 pandemic?
2. What factors influence children's preference for online learning over onsite learning?
3. What benefits do children experience when engaging in online learning compared to onsite learning in the post-pandemic context?

Theoretical Framework

1. Community of Inquiry Theory (Garrison et al., 2000)

Effective learning happens when **Cognitive Presence + Teaching Presence + Social Presence work together**.

Cognitive Presence → how learners understand and construct knowledge

- **Teaching Presence** → how teachers guide and structure learning
- **Social Presence** → how learners interact and feel connected
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2. Constructivist Learning Theory (Vygotsky, 1978)

Learning is a social and active process where children build knowledge through,

Interaction

- **Guidance**
- **Experience**
-

Online learning supports independent learning. Yet, reduced physical interaction may affect collaboration, communication skills social learning,

Methodology

Research Design

Qualitative research approach

Study Area

Elpitiya Divisional Secretariat Division, Galle District, Sri Lanka

Participants

Children aged 11-15 years currently enrolled in upper secondary education and actively using online learning platforms with access to digital devices and internet connectivity.

Sampling

Purposive Sampling

Data Collection Tools

Semi-structured interviews

- 10 Children (6 females and 4 males)

Focus Group Discussions.

- *2 Groups (8 Children per group *2 = 16)*

Data Analysis

Deductive Thematic Analysis

Key Findings

Theme 1: Flexibility for Online Learning

Explained by: Community of Inquiry Theory (Cognitive Presence)

Flexibility allows self-paced explorational learning.

Ability to revise recorded lessons support for deep understanding.

Facility of zero transport cost is needed for visiting onsite study locations.

Theme 2: Availability of Online Learning Resources

Explained by: Community of Inquiry Theory (Cognitive + Teaching Presence)

Most of the houses are available at least with a smart phone these days.

When the robust internet facility is available online classrooms are no longer a challenge

Can ask questions on a one-click sitting before digital devices.

Structured resources facilitate teacher guidance.

Continued.....

Theme 3: Factors Influencing Technology Preference

Explained by: Community of Inquiry Theory (Teaching Presence)

Teacher communication through platforms

Ability to revise recorded lessons multiple time especially for challenging subjects

Organized delivery of lessons while important lessons parts are not missed.

Using AI without lagging longer for manual methods for the same study purpose.

Theme 4: Social Interactions in Online Learning Modalities

Explained by: Lev Vygotsky's Constructivist Learning Theory

Learning requires interaction and collaboration

Online learning reduces peer communication, group learning, social engagement

(Creative thinking is limited in online learning environments, as technology often provides highly structured and ready-made answers even for essay writing which can lead to unintentional copy-paste practices and create a culture of dependency)

Continued...

Theme 5: Post-Pandemic Learning Expectations

Explained by: Lev Vygotsky's Constructivist Learning Theory

Children prefer blended learning

Need both:

Independent learning (online)
Social interaction (classroom)

None of the children identified either method as universally superior. They noted that challenges exist in both approaches such as effectiveness of each depends on the availability of resources, pedagogical design and the specific context in which it is implemented

Disussion and Analysis

Research Question 1

What are children's perceptions regarding online learning during the COVID-19 pandemic?

How it is addressed: This question is mainly answered through,

- Theme 1: Flexibility for Online Learning
- Theme 2: Availability of Online Learning Resources

Research Question 2

What factors influence children's preference for online learning over onsite learning?

How it is addressed: This question is mainly answered through,

- Theme 3: Factors Influencing Technology Preference

Continued….

Research Question 3

What benefits do children experience when engaging in online learning compared to onsite learning in the post-pandemic context?

How it is addressed:

This question is answered through,

- Theme 1: Flexibility for Online Learning
- Theme 2: Availability of Resources
- Theme 3: Technology Preference Factors

Continued….

Theme 5: Post-Pandemic Learning Expectations

Linked to: Balance of all three presences

Children want:

- Cognitive benefits (flexibility)
- Teaching support (guidance)
- Social interaction (classroom)

References

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Thank you for your attention.